

ELECTORAL POLITICS AND DEMOCRATIC GOVERNANCE IN NIGERIA: POLITICAL ECONOMY PERSPECTIVE

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the influence of political and economic interests on electoral processes and democratic governance in Nigeria. Guided by the political economy perspective, the research employs content analysis of empirical studies covering the period from 1999 to 2023. The analysis synthesizes findings from multiple studies to explore how elite behavior, structural economic conditions, and institutional weaknesses shape elections and governance outcomes. The findings reveal that Nigeria's democracy is heavily influenced by elite dominance, corruption, monetization of politics, ethnic manipulation, and weak institutions, resulting in elections that are largely procedural rather than substantive. Poverty and economic inequality further distort voter behavior and limit political participation. The study concludes that democratic consolidation in Nigeria remains fragile, with governance driven by self-interest rather than public welfare. To strengthen democracy, the study recommends enhancing institutional capacity, promoting internal party democracy, curbing corruption and elite manipulation, improving civic education, and addressing structural economic challenges to foster inclusive participation and accountable governance.

Keywords: Election, Politics, Democracy, Governance.

Introduction

Elections remain a fundamental pillar of democratic governance. The quality and credibility of electoral politics largely determine the strength and sustainability of any democratic system. In democratic societies, elections serve not only as mechanisms for leadership recruitment but also as instruments for ensuring accountability, legitimacy, and citizen participation in governance. As Nnoli (2003) observes, elections represent the single most important indicator of democratic practice, while Edo (2012) emphasizes their universal acceptance as the hallmark of democracy. Similarly, Elaigwu (2014) emphasizes that, elections as vehicles for establishing representative government.

The relationship between electoral politics and democratic governance is therefore inseparable. Sustaining democratic governance depends on credible political competition among individuals and organized groups. Diamond (1988) argues that democracy thrives when there is healthy competition among political actors, adherence to civil and political rights, and active citizen participation. Hence, the success or failure of democratic practice depends on the conduct of elections, patterns of political mobilization, and the overall political culture of a society.

Despite the centrality of elections to democratic governance, Nigeria's experience has been characterized by persistent challenges that undermine democratic consolidation. After over two decades of civilian rule since 1999, issues such as weak institutions, electoral malpractice, political violence, and the erosion of the rule of law continue to threaten Nigeria's democratic stability (Ijere, 2015). These realities reflect a deficit in the credibility of the electoral system and the absence of sustained political accountability. The recurring manipulation of electoral processes by political elites further erodes public trust in governance and diminishes the quality of democracy. From a political economy perspective, these challenges are best understood as products of the structural and historical conditions of the Nigerian state. The behavior of the political class toward elections reflects the interplay between political power and economic interests. Weak economic structures and the prevalence of poverty often motivate the political elite to view elections as opportunities to capture state resources and consolidate personal wealth. This "politics of survival" distorts democratic values and promotes a winner-takes-all mentality that undermines institutional development.

Recent political developments, such as the tensions and crisis surrounding governance and leadership struggles in Rivers State in 2025, illustrate how competition for state power often overrides democratic norms. Allegations of executive interference, legislative conflict, and political manipulation reveal how state power is weaponized for partisan advantage. Such incidents demonstrate that electoral politics in Nigeria often serve as an arena for elite contestation rather than a platform for promoting public interest or democratic consolidation.

The study seeks to examine how political and economic interests shape electoral processes and outcomes in Nigeria, assess the extent to which the behavior of political actors influences the credibility of elections and democratic consolidation, analyze how structural economic factors affect voter behavior and political participation, and explore the implications of the political economy of elections for governance and institutional development in the country. To achieve these objectives, the study employs content analysis as its methodological approach. This method involves systematically reviewing and interpreting existing literature, official reports, electoral documents, and media sources to identify patterns and themes linking economic structures, political behavior, and electoral outcomes. By applying this qualitative approach within the framework of the Political Economy theory, the study provides deeper insights into how material interests and state control shape Nigeria's electoral politics and the broader dynamics of democratic governance.

CONCEPTUAL AND THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

Election

Election refers to the process through which representatives are selected for political office by the choice of voters (Johari, 2003; Nnoli, 2003). This process, guided by legal and institutional frameworks, enables citizens to choose their leaders through periodic, free, and fair contests. Larry

and Lipold (2022) describe electoral politics as a process of class competition and conflict within democratic systems, where individuals vote based on social and economic divisions, leading to shifts in political alignments over time.

For the purpose of this study, electoral politics is defined as the competition among political actors and institutions for the control of state power. It encompasses all behaviors, activities, and interactions that occur before, during, and after elections—including political mobilization, party organization, campaign strategies, and the role of electoral institutions such as the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC). It also involves the participation of other key stakeholders such as political parties, security agencies, civil society organizations, the media, and the electorate.

Democratic Governance

The term “democracy,” derived from the Greek words *demos* (people) and *kratia* (rule), literally means “rule by the people” (Appadorai, 2004). Democratic governance refers to a system of government in which authority derives from the consent of the governed and is exercised within a framework of constitutionalism, rule of law, and respect for human rights (Anifowose & Enemuo, 1999).

According to Elaigwu (2014), democratic governance is characterized by the sovereignty of the people, majority rule with minority rights, periodic elections, the rule of law, accountability, transparency, and the protection of civil liberties. Jega (2007) further emphasizes that legitimacy in a democracy is grounded in citizens’ participation and representation, where government authority operates within constitutional limits.

Historical Patterns and Thematic Dimensions of Electoral Politics in Nigeria

The historical evolution of electoral politics in Nigeria reflects the complex interplay of ethnicity, regionalism, party ideology, militarism, and reform efforts. Understanding these themes provides insight into how Nigeria’s political economy has shaped electoral behavior and governance outcomes.

Colonial Foundations and the Rise of Regional Politics (1922–1960)

The introduction of the elective principle in the Clifford Constitution of 1922 marked the beginning of electoral politics in Nigeria. However, participation was highly restrictive limited to adult males of a certain income status (Nnadozie, 2007). The formation of the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) by Herbert Macaulay inaugurated formal party politics, though under colonial constraints. With the Richards Constitution of 1946 and subsequent constitutional reforms, regional identities became the basis for political competition. Political parties emerged largely along ethnic lines: the Northern People’s Congress (NPC) in the North, the Action Group (AG) in the West, and the National Council of Nigerian Citizens (NCNC) in the East (Nnoli, 1980). This regionalization of politics entrenched ethnic competition, a trend that would persist in Nigeria’s post-independence politics.

Post-Independence Politics and the Crisis of Integration (1960–1979)

The First Republic (1960–1966) inherited the colonial legacy of ethnic and regional polarization. The 1964 general elections exposed the fragility of Nigeria’s democratic institutions as political alliances collapsed, violence erupted, and electoral malpractices became widespread (Dudley, 1982). These events culminated in the 1966 military coup, ending the First Republic. Following years of military rule, the Second Republic (1979–1983) attempted to restore democracy through a new constitutional framework emphasizing federal balance and national integration. Despite these efforts, the replication of old regional loyalties and the dominance of elite interests undermined democratic stability. The 1983 elections, marred by fraud and violence, again resulted in the collapse of civil rule (Nnadozie, 2007).

Transition Politics and Militarized Electoral Experiments (1985–1999)

Nigeria’s electoral politics during the late 1980s and 1990s were defined by prolonged transition programs under military regimes. The Third Republic experiment under General Babangida introduced the two-party system—Social Democratic Party (SDP) and National Republican Convention (NRC)—to reduce ethnic polarization (Omotola, 2009). The June 12, 1993 Presidential Election, widely regarded as Nigeria’s freest and fairest, was annulled, demonstrating the military’s manipulation of the democratic process for political control. Under General Sani Abacha (1993–1998), electoral politics became a façade for authoritarian consolidation, as all five registered political parties endorsed the incumbent in a planned self-succession agenda. The return to democracy in 1999 under General Abdulsalami Abubakar’s transition program marked a critical turning point, inaugurating the Fourth Republic.

Democratic Consolidation and Electoral Reform Challenges (1999–Present)

Since 1999, Nigeria has conducted seven consecutive general elections—a notable achievement in its democratic history. However, the pattern of electoral politics remains shaped by elite interests, monetization, and weak institutions.

- **Ethnicity and Regionalism:** The 1999 and 2003 elections were influenced by the informal zoning arrangement designed to stabilize power-sharing between regions, yet ethnic considerations continued to influence voter alignment and party strategy.
- **Party Ideology and Opposition Politics:** The 2015 general election, which saw the opposition All Progressives Congress (APC) defeat the ruling People’s Democratic Party (PDP), represented a milestone in Nigeria’s democratic development. However, the ideological distinction between parties remained blurred, as coalitions were formed primarily for electoral advantage rather than policy vision.
- **Militarism and Electoral Conduct:** Despite a shift to civilian rule, electoral politics has retained a militarized character—evident in the use of security forces during elections, intimidation of opposition parties, and manipulation of electoral outcomes. The “do-or-die” approach to elections, popularized in the mid-2000s, continues to distort democratic competition.

- Electoral Reforms and Institutional Weakness: Efforts by the Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) to introduce technological innovations, such as the Bimodal Voter Accreditation System (BVAS) and electronic transmission of results, in the 2023 elections signify incremental progress. Yet, issues of vote-buying, voter suppression, and judicial intervention in post-election disputes reveal persistent institutional fragility.

Electoral Politics and Democratic Governance in Nigeria: Political Economy Perspective

There are several dimensions to the issue of electoral politics and democratic governance in Nigeria which are beyond the scope of this paper. However, it is pertinent to approach the subject matter from political economy perspective in order to unravel the historical nature of the problem. Political economy perspective entails that, like most other emerging democracies in the Third World Countries (TWCs), the nature of political contest in Nigeria can be explained in the context of historical and socio-economic reality of the post - colonial state. In line with this philosophy is the argument of Laski (1967) that the study of politics concerns itself with the life of men in relation to organized state. Political economy perspective on the nature of electoral politics in Nigeria suggests a definite correlation between democratic governance and weak economic base of the political class. Thus, the political economy philosophy will have as its point of departure the material existence and socio-economic reality of the Nigerian state. This is based on the assumption that social existence or economic condition of people is the sole determinant of man's life, ideals, beliefs and value judgement (Akpuru-Aja, 1997i).

Therefore, to understand the nature of electoral politics in Nigeria requires an insight into the historical existence and nature of the Nigerian colonial and post-colonial state. Ake (2001) argues that colonialism in Africa was usually statist; and the circumstances of the colonial state reduced politics to the crude mechanics of opposing forces driven by the calculus of power as security only laid in the accumulation of power. Ake further maintains that although political independence brought some changes to the composition of state managers, the character of the state remained much as it was in the colonial era. Therefore, post-colonial politics in Africa and Nigeria has been shaped by the circumstances of post-colonial state and political competition arising from the value placed on the control of state power. The increased premium on political power and intensity of political competition is further reinforced by the tendency to use state power for accumulation.

In Nigeria and Africa at large, there are concerns about the sustainability of democracy given the parlous state of African economies (Nyango, 1988). After several years of transition to civilian rule, Nigeria democratic project remains fragile with weak economic base. The weak material base of the Nigerian economy meant that the political class have one leverage: the control of state power to strengthen their economic base (Ake, 2001). Therefore, political power in Nigerian is seen as a commodity that can be acquired by all means including the adoption of Machiavellian tactics and amoral principles outlined in his book, *The Prince*, on how to gain, expand and retain power. By this scenario, the idea of lawful political contest becomes impossible in the Nigerian political landscape.

Although the political economy approach has been criticized by the bourgeois scholars that it amounts to economic determinism or a uni-linear analysis of society, it does not suggest that the economic structure is autonomous and strictly deterministic. All the social structures are, to some extent, interdependent and interact in complex ways. Each one of them affects the character of every other one and is in turn affected by it. Thus, it is not wrong to argue that competition for power in Nigeria is usually driven by the motivation of the political class to capture and control state resources. There is no doubt that the nature of electoral politics in Nigeria is not conducive for the growth and sustainability of democratic governance. Electoral politics in Nigeria is built on poor political orientation of the political class as well as weak institutions of democratic governance, such as political parties, the media, legal framework, and so on.

At the heart of examining the health of any form of democracy are political parties. This is because the strength and effectiveness of political parties in a democracy are directly proportional to the degree of success such system enjoys (Izom, Aliyu & Wakili, 2024). However, political parties in Nigeria are deficient in their role in deepening democratic governance. A study by International Republican Institute (2020) indicates that despite recent progress, political parties in Nigeria remain beset by corrupt practices and do not consistently reflect the priority of Nigerian people. As argued by Ezomiwu (2024):

despite all the legal backing, the output of political parties in Nigeria leaves much to be desired. While political parties are strong institutions in other climes, in Nigeria, they are very weak. This weakness makes them unable to perform effectively their roles in the political system, thereby stunting the growth of democracy in the country.

Generally, political parties in Nigeria are basically positioned to capture power, use and maintain it using all means possible. Nigeria experience with electoral politics demonstrates that majority of the registered political parties exist on the paper without any active role in the electoral process. Political parties exist in Nigeria only for the sake of it; they are neither strong nor active (Ezomiwu, 2024). Thus, many political parties do not only exist in names or at the crucial point in the distribution of funds. Evidently, electoral politics, especially in the 4th Republic, is usually dominated by two or three political parties in spite of the large number of registered political parties. More so, electoral politics in Nigeria is generally devoid of internal party democracy. The circumstances in which candidates are processed by the various political parties are not conducive for the stability and sustainability of electoral politics and democratic governance. Political party candidates usually emerged through rigging, intimidation, imposition as well as the use of money and incumbent factor. In most cases, the candidates for the political parties are not only prepared, but also incompetent and lack the necessary qualities to occupy positions they are nominated for. Relatedly, political parties in Nigeria are not only weak, but also produce politicians that are stronger than the institutions of democratic governance.

Further, Nigerian political class has imbibed undemocratic political culture which impedes a healthy and smooth political contest in Nigeria. The political elite are not disposed to a political

culture of tolerance as an important democratic value. In some instances, the activities of political parties as well as the attitudes of their candidates towards political contest have contributed to intra-party and inter-party conflicts. Consequently, electoral politics in Nigeria is usually characterised by atmosphere of insecurity, hostility, tension, fear and anxiety as the political parties and their candidates are not prepared to accept defeat or abide by the rule of the game. The Code of Conduct and signing of Peace Accord by political parties have been ineffective, except in 2015 when the incumbent President conceded defeat without resorting to violence.

Electoral politics in Nigeria is also defined by the conduct and activities of political parties and their candidates towards electoral campaigns. Politics in Nigeria is not seen as a game, but as a battle where nothing succeeds as much as success and nothing fails as much as failure and the exclusion of political failures has always been a major source of conflict (Elaigwu, 2014). Thus, to acquire and maintain power, the politicians usually resort to any means including exploiting ethnic, regional and religious sentiments to gain support. The trend of do - or - die - politics does not only affect the electoral process, but also sets negative tune for political tension, hostility and hatred even after elections as the party that formed government usually tend to patronise only its supporters. More importantly, Nigerian politicians are deeply consumed by competition for political power to the extent that they find it difficult to separate party politics from governance. Relatedly, the political class have paid little or no attention to nurturing a robust debate culture as an essential ingredient of electoral politics in the country. Electoral debate is an international practice which enables voters to understand issues better and make up their mind on who to vote for. However, the culture of electoral debate has not taken firm roots in Nigerian political system. Critical to the practice of electoral politics in Nigeria is the role of the media as a critical component of democratic governance. Mu'azu (2003) argues that, in the era of politics, assumption is that the media would serve as platform not only for the provision of information to the citizenry, but also as important instrument in the mobilization of the people and providing civic education for them to play their role in the democratic process. Electoral battles in Nigeria are mostly fought on the pages of newspapers, televisions, radio stations and social media. Thus, as the "fourth estate of the realm", the media plays an important role in shaping the conduct of electoral politics in the country. However, despite the role played by the media, including the burgeoning internet media, especially by linking political parties and their candidate with the electorates, the media has not lived up to its responsibility of promoting values of democratic governance in the country. The media, especially print, has behaved more like attack dogs of certain partisan interests than the watchdog of a country labouring hard to build democracy (Haruna, 2014). The media usually neglect its constitutional responsibility and standard ethics of media profession. In some instances, the media has contributed to create electoral violence and overheating the polity. Most media outfits are partisan and only serve as instruments of destruction in the hands of the politicians. In most cases, the owners of media outfits are appointed to head campaign teams of political parties.

The use of money is also a key factor of the electoral politics in Nigeria. Although money is critical to the functioning of any political system, the Nigerian experience shows that the political class have no regard to the rules and regulations concerning electoral finance. For instance, it can hardly be confirmed that politicians and their political parties usually comply with the provisions for spending limits of One Billion Naira (N1bn) and Two Hundred Million Naira (N200m) for Presidential and Governorship candidates respectively, as well as the requirements for submission of audited election expenses to INEC within 6 months after an election as stipulated by the Electoral Act 2010 (as amended). Indeed, it is difficult, if not impossible, to obtain actual and reliable information on how much money is spent during the election period by the political parties and their candidates in Nigeria

Although cases of violation of campaign finance regulations are noted even in advanced democracies, such as Germany, Italy, France, Belgium, United Kingdom and Spain (Hopkin, 2004), the magnitude of this act is alarming in most African countries including Nigeria. Owing to the gaps in the legal provisions and the political behaviour of Nigerian political elite who always show no regard to the rules of political contest, efforts to regulate expenditure during political contest in Nigeria have yielded unsatisfactory results. In most cases, the ruling party and the incumbents use state resources to fund their campaigns. More so, political parties and their candidates usually indulge in bribery, financial inducement, buying of voters' cards, sponsoring hate campaigns, renting of crowd and use of government agencies as conduit to siphon state funds. Associated with the role of money in Nigeria's electoral politics is the problem of lack of proper funding of political parties. Political parties in Nigeria are very poor financially; and the paucity of funds renders them unable to participate effectively in elections (Ezowimu, 2024). The failure to fund political parties since 1999 had left the electoral process into the whims and caprices of money bags. By using their financial muscle, the money bags are always finding it easy to tamper with democratic ideals in their quest for power, leading to lack of internal party democracy in political parties.

Evidently, both the electoral institutions and the laws have exhibited inadequacies to address the violation of regulations on electoral finance in Nigeria. As a result, instead of issues-driven campaigns, electoral contest is reduced to a commercial activity where the use of money takes centre stage in electoral politics. The manner in which political parties and their candidates mobilize huge funds has exposed the blatant corruption and commercialization of the electoral process in the country. Excessive spending by political class encourages corruption in the system which eventually cripples Nigerian economy. This trend of money politics does not encourage the growth and sustainability of democratic governance in Nigeria.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

The study adopts Political Economy theory provides a framework for understanding the nexus between politics and economics, particularly how material and structural conditions shape political behavior and institutions. The theory originated from the works of Karl Marx (1859), who

posited that the economic base of a society determines its political and ideological superstructure. Subsequent thinkers such as Harold Lasswell (1936), David Easton (1953), and Claude Ake (1981) expanded this perspective by analysing how economic interests, class relations, and state structures influence political actions and outcomes.

The approach views political competition not merely as a contest of ideas, but as a struggle for control over economic resources and opportunities. In societies like Nigeria where state is the primary source of wealth distribution politics becomes the principal means of economic survival. Hence, electoral politics are often characterized by patronage, prebendalism, rent-seeking, and clientelism, as politicians and elites deploy economic incentives to secure political loyalty and dominance (Escudé, 2021).

Applicability of the Political Economy Theory

The Political Economy theory explain the character and workings of electoral politics in Nigeria. Elections particularly in Nigeria goes beyond democratic participation but often seen as contests for control of state power, which grants access to wealth, patronage, and social influence. Because Nigeria's economy is highly centralized and the state plays a dominant role in resource distribution, holding political office is widely viewed as the most direct path to economic advancement.

Thus, the theory lens demonstrates the root causes of Nigeria's electoral crises violence, corruption, and poor governance that are not merely procedural but structural, embedded in the economic motivations behind political participation and power acquisition.

Relevance of the Political Economy Theory to the Study

The theory is significant because it offers a conceptual and analytical framework for examining how economic conditions influence voting behavior and electoral outcomes in Nigeria. In particular, the theory helps to highlight:

- i. **The Material Basis of Electoral Politics:** It explains why poverty, unemployment, and inequality make voters vulnerable to incentives and manipulation.
- ii. **The Motivation of Political Actors:** It highlights how political elites pursue elections as economic ventures aimed at accessing state resources rather than promoting public welfare.
- iii. **The Structure of Power Relations:** It clarifies the link between economic dependency, patron-client relationships, and the consolidation of elite dominance.
- iv. **Policy Implications:** It suggests that genuine electoral reform and democratic consolidation must address underlying economic disparities and the monopolization of wealth by political elites.

Through the application this theory, provide the relationship between the Nigeria's economic conditions with behavior of political actors and voters. This connection provides a

deeper understanding of the persistent issues of electoral corruption, fragile democratic institutions, and inefficiencies in governance.

Empirical Review

Ajoge and Yahaya (2023) examines how Nigeria's democratic governments from 1999 to 2023 have managed public resources and their impact on citizens' welfare. Using a qualitative design and secondary data, and guided by the Marxian Political Economy theory, the authors find that despite over two decades of uninterrupted democracy, issues such as corruption, insecurity, and elite dominance persist. They argue that political elites often manipulate state policies for personal gain, undermining development and democratic stability. The study concludes that moral leadership, sincerity, and the eradication of corruption are essential for achieving genuine democracy in Nigeria. Its main limitation is the exclusive reliance on secondary data without primary evidence.

Zainawa (n.d.) examines the role of political parties in Nigeria's democratic and electoral processes, emphasizing their importance as platforms for citizen representation, policy choice, and mass mobilization. It argues that, ideally, parties in a liberal democracy should promote credible, transparent, and fair elections that advance public welfare. However, the paper finds that Nigerian political parties have failed to uphold these democratic ideals due to issues such as godfatherism, disregard for internal party rules, manipulation, corruption, and electoral malpractice. Using secondary data, the study concludes that political parties in Nigeria have largely abandoned their roles of interest articulation and aggregation, thereby undermining the credibility of elections and democracy. It recommends the enforcement of internal party democracy, the elimination of electoral rigging and godfatherism, and a change in politicians' attitudes toward party politics, stressing that democracy cannot thrive without democrats.

Oni, Chidozie, and Agbude (2013), examines how security agencies influence the credibility of elections in Nigeria's Fourth Republic. Using both primary and secondary data, including questionnaires from 1,200 respondents in Lagos, Ogun, and Oyo States, the findings reveal that the main issue lies in *how* the police perform their electoral duties rather than whether they perform them. It concludes that electoral reforms must include the reform of security agencies to ensure credible elections. The author is commended for highlighting the overlooked role of security institutions, though the study's limited geographic scope and lack of deeper qualitative data are notable weaknesses.

Arowolo and Aluko (2012) investigates the relationship between democracy, political participation, and good governance in Nigeria. It argues that, despite over a decade of democratic practice, the expected outcomes of accountability, transparency, and responsive governance have not been realized. Using content analysis and guided by the elite theory, the study finds that electoral violence, result manipulation, and limited citizen participation have hindered democratic consolidation and, consequently, good governance. The authors contend that governance failure

in Nigeria stems from the self-serving and superficial actions of political elites who prioritize personal interests over public welfare. The paper concludes that achieving genuine democracy and good governance in Nigeria requires inclusive political participation, accountability, and a fundamental change in the conduct of political actors.

Adetula (2015) examines how money and violence shape Nigeria's electoral politics, emphasizing their deep-rooted and destructive effects on democratic consolidation. It highlights that since 1999, elections in Nigeria have been consistently marred by violence, corruption, and the dominance of political godfathers and wealthy elites, who manipulate ethnic and religious sentiments to maintain power. Drawing on surveys, media reports, and observer findings from the 2015 elections, the study identifies a pattern where money politics and electoral violence reinforce each other, undermining credibility and citizen trust.

Odewuyi, Chiazor, and Ajayi (2025) explores the relationship between elections, governance cycles, and economic performance in Nigeria through the lens of political economy theory. Covering the period from 1999 to 2023, it analyses how democratic transitions and electoral behavior influence fiscal discipline, policy stability, and overall economic outcomes. Using the historical research method and secondary data from official records and scholarly sources, the study finds that Nigerian elections often trigger political budget cycles, characterized by increased spending, deficits, and inflation before elections. Governance transitions commonly lead to policy discontinuities, with successive governments abandoning prior economic plans, thereby eroding institutional trust and economic stability. Despite periods of growth, challenges such as unemployment, inflation, and poverty persist—largely due to weak institutions, oil dependency, and rent-seeking politics.

The study concludes that although Nigeria's democracy has endured since 1999, its economic dividends are limited by governance patterns that favor short-term political gains over sustainable development. It recommends strengthening fiscal institutions, ensuring policy continuity through national development plans, diversifying the economy, and implementing electoral and institutional reforms to reduce political distortions and promote inclusive growth.

Oji, Okeke, Orisakwe, and Olemeforo (2024) examines the impact of ethnic politics on democratic governance in Nigeria between 2015 and 2023. It observes that since independence in 1960, Nigeria's politics has been deeply influenced by ethnic divisions, where political relevance is often determined by one's ethnic affiliation. The persistence of ethnic politics has undermined democratic growth, threatened national unity, and hindered good governance. Rooted in colonial legacies that favored the three major ethnic groups, ethnicity continues to serve as a tool for political manipulation and exclusion of minority groups. Using a qualitative research method based on secondary sources such as books, journals, and online materials, and guided by Group Theory, the study finds that ethnic politics fosters inequality, favoritism, and alienation in governance. Political appointments and promotions are often determined by ethnicity, religion, or

party loyalty rather than merit, thereby deepening political crises and weakening national cohesion.

The study concludes that Nigeria's democratic progress requires a constitutional and political restructuring that promotes equity, national interest, and inclusive political participation. Such reforms are essential to replace the outdated framework inherited from military rule and to strengthen democratic governance.

From the researcher's perspective, the reviewed empirical studies collectively demonstrate that the core challenge to Nigeria's democratic consolidation lies in the entrenchment of elite interests and the weak institutional framework governing the state. The recurring themes of corruption, ethnic manipulation, money politics, and policy inconsistency point to a political economy driven by self-interest rather than collective welfare. In the researcher's view, democracy in Nigeria has largely become procedural rather than substantive elections are held regularly, yet their outcomes seldom translate into good governance or improved socioeconomic conditions.

Furthermore, the persistent dominance of political godfathers, the erosion of internal party democracy, and the monetization of politics suggest that democratic institutions have been captured by powerful elites who use them to maintain control rather than promote accountability. The researcher therefore posits that sustainable democratic governance in Nigeria requires a fundamental reorientation of political values, strengthening of institutional checks and balances, and genuine commitment to rule of law and inclusivity. Without these reforms, democracy in Nigeria risks remaining a façade that legitimizes elite exploitation under the guise of popular sovereignty.

Content Analysis

To accomplish the aims of this study, content analysis was carried out based on insights gathered from existing empirical studies on the interaction between political economy, electoral processes, and democratic governance in Nigeria. The analysis brings together evidence from prior research to illustrate how political and economic interests, elite actions, and structural factors collectively influence electoral outcomes and patterns of governance in the country.

Ajoge and Yahaya (2023) highlight how political elites manipulate public resources for personal and group advantage, reflecting a structural imbalance where state institutions serve the interests of the ruling class rather than the broader populace. This aligns with the Marxian Political Economy perspective that views political behavior as an extension of economic control. The persistence of corruption, insecurity, and policy inconsistency indicates that economic powerholders largely dictate the direction of democratic governance.

Similarly, Zainawa (n.d.) exposes the internal dysfunction within political parties, noting that godfatherism, lack of internal democracy, and corruption have undermined their representative role. This supports the first objective of the study, which emphasizes how political and economic interests distort electoral processes. Parties, rather than serving as vehicles for citizen participation and accountability, often operate as instruments for elite consolidation of power, weakening electoral integrity and public trust.

Oni, Chidozie, and Agbude (2013) extend this analysis to the role of security institutions in elections, showing that coercive apparatuses of the state are frequently deployed to influence electoral outcomes. Their findings suggest that the credibility of elections is often compromised not only by politicians but also by institutional actors who are economically or politically aligned with the ruling elite. This reinforces the notion that political behavior and institutional performance are deeply intertwined with class interests and the broader economic structure.

The study by Arowolo and Aluko (2012) adds another layer by demonstrating how limited political participation and elite-driven governance hinder democratic consolidation. Their use of the elite theory underscores that governance in Nigeria remains exclusionary, serving a minority while alienating the majority. This resonates with the third objective of the present study, which seeks to understand how structural and economic conditions shape citizen participation and voting behavior.

Adetula (2015) provides empirical evidence on how money and violence distort the electoral environment, showing that financial inducements and coercion are central mechanisms through which elites sustain their dominance. The link between economic inequality and electoral manipulation is evident in how wealthy politicians exploit poverty and insecurity to buy votes and suppress opposition. This further explains the persistent disconnect between democratic procedures and developmental outcomes.

Odewuyi, Chiazor, and Ajayi (2025) examine the cyclical relationship between elections, governance, and economic performance, demonstrating how electoral periods often trigger unsustainable fiscal behavior—such as excessive spending and inflation—driven by short-term political motives. Their findings underscore that Nigeria's political economy is characterized by policy instability and rent-seeking, with governance transitions frequently disrupting economic progress. This aligns with the objective of exploring how structural economic dynamics affect political stability and institutional development.

The contribution of Oji, Okeke, Orisakwe, and Olemeforo (2024) highlights the role of ethnic politics as a structural impediment to democratic governance. Their analysis shows that ethnicity functions as both a political and economic tool used by elites to distribute state resources unevenly and maintain regional loyalties. This ethno-political manipulation deepens division and

perpetuates governance inefficiency, thereby undermining national cohesion and democratic growth.

From a synthesized perspective, the studies reveal that Nigeria's democracy operates within a framework of elite capture, where political and economic power are concentrated in the hands of a few. Elections, though regular, often fail to produce transformative governance due to the commodification of votes, weak institutional frameworks, and the absence of ideological commitment among political actors. Consequently, the democratic process becomes more procedural than substantive, focusing on winning power rather than advancing public welfare.

Findings

Objective 1: To examine how political and economic interests shape electoral processes and outcomes in Nigeria.

The study finds that Nigeria's electoral system is largely influenced by the dominance of political and economic elites who manipulate institutions and resources to secure political advantage. Elections are often characterized by money politics, corruption, and godfatherism, which distort the true will of the electorate. The concentration of economic power in the hands of a few enables the wealthy to influence candidate selection and policy direction. Consequently, electoral outcomes tend to reflect elite interests rather than public choice, thereby undermining the principles of democratic competition and representation.

Objective 2: To assess the extent to which the behavior of political actors influences the credibility of elections and democratic consolidation.

The behavior of political actors significantly affects electoral credibility and the consolidation of democracy in Nigeria. Many political leaders exhibit unethical practices such as vote buying, manipulation of electoral institutions, and disregard for the rule of law. These actions weaken electoral integrity and erode public trust in the system. Furthermore, the self-serving attitudes of politicians who often prioritize personal gain over national development have turned politics into a tool of enrichment rather than public

service. This has hindered the institutionalization of democratic norms, thereby impeding Nigeria's democratic consolidation.

Objective 3: To analyze how structural economic factors affect voter behavior and political participation.

Structural economic conditions such as poverty, unemployment, and economic inequality have profound effects on voter behavior and participation. The high rate of poverty makes many citizens vulnerable to financial inducement, reducing elections to transactional activities. Economic hardship discourages political participation, as citizens lose confidence in the ability of government to improve their welfare. Moreover, electoral periods are often marked by unsustainable fiscal practices and economic disruptions, including excessive spending and inflation, which further weaken trust in the political system and limit active civic engagement.

Objective 4: To explore the implications of the political economy of elections for governance and institutional development in Nigeria.

The findings reveal that the political economy of elections has far-reaching implications for governance and institutional development. The monetization of politics and capture of democratic institutions by elites have led to policy instability, corruption, and poor governance outcomes. Ethnic and religious manipulation continues to deepen social divisions and undermine national cohesion. Consequently, democracy in Nigeria remains procedural rather than substantive elections occur regularly, yet they seldom result in accountability, transparency, or improved public welfare. The persistence of elite dominance and weak institutional frameworks sustains a governance system driven by self-interest rather than collective development.

CONCLUSION

The study finds that Nigeria's democracy is heavily influenced by elite control, corruption, and economic manipulation, which undermine electoral credibility and democratic consolidation. Political actors often prioritize personal gain over public interest, while poverty and inequality

distort voter behavior and limit participation. As a result, elections remain largely procedural, delivering little in terms of accountability or improved governance. Sustainable democracy in Nigeria requires stronger institutions, internal party democracy, transparency, and inclusive political participation to shift the system from elite dominance to people-centered governance.

Recommendations

1. Strengthen Institutional Frameworks:

Nigerian democratic institutions should be empowered and reformed to ensure transparency, accountability, and impartiality in electoral and governance processes. This includes enhancing the capacity of electoral commissions, security agencies, and anti-corruption bodies to enforce rules effectively.

2. Promote Internal Party Democracy:

Political parties must institutionalize internal democracy by enforcing transparent candidate selection processes, reducing godfatherism, and ensuring active participation of party members in decision-making. This will help align party operations with democratic principles and improve the credibility of elections.

3. Curb Corruption and Elite Manipulation:

Anti-corruption measures should be strengthened to reduce the influence of elites over electoral and governance processes. Policies that limit vote buying, financial inducements, and misuse of public resources can help ensure that elections reflect the genuine will of the people.

4. Enhance Civic Education and Participation:

Citizens should be empowered through continuous political and civic education to make informed choices and resist manipulation during elections. Encouraging active participation in governance beyond voting will strengthen democratic accountability and citizen engagement.

5. Address Structural Economic Challenges:

Government policies should focus on reducing poverty, unemployment, and inequality to limit the economic vulnerabilities that allow political elites to manipulate voters.

Sustainable economic reforms, including job creation, social welfare programs, and equitable resource distribution, will support more informed and independent political participation.

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